

» T20 WORLD CUP PACKAGE PLAYER OF THE TOURNAMENT



Crown jewel: Sanju Samson earned the Player-of-the-tournament award for bludgeoning 321 runs in just five matches in the T20 World Cup. VIJAY SONEJI

A 'Superman' in flesh, blood and glory

Cricket may be a team sport, but India's T20 World Cup campaign might have well been buried six feet under if not for Sanju Samson's **belligerent** interventions.

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Lost in the tide of jersey sellers outside the Narendra Modi Stadium, a little boy sat cross-legged on the pavement, presiding over a tiny universe of cricket posters, plastic toys, dog-eared first copies of popular paperbacks, and, somewhat improbably, a few old comic books.

One of them, its soft cover fluttering in the Ahmedabad breeze, appeared to belong to DC's coveted

All-Star Superman series.

It beckoned from the corner like a forgotten relic, but the stadium gates were still some distance away, and the traffic ahead churned like a stubborn sea of blue. **For the moment, it seemed wiser to cut through the chaos and keep moving. One could always come back, was the thought.**

Once inside the venue, the world outside was quickly forgotten as India was put in to bat in the T20 World Cup final. Even if there was a ghost of an afterthought that lingered, it was quickly swallowed by

an LBW appeal off the very second ball that Sanju Samson faced. New Zealand's Matt Henry had just gotten it to nip back in. Even as UltraEdge revealed a spike, the tension in the stands quickly subsided.

Samson had walked into the game riding a blazing run of form: an 89 in the semifinal against England and an unbeaten 97 in the must-win Super Eight clash against West Indies. Cricket may be a team sport, but India's campaign might have well been buried six feet under if not for Samson's belligerent interventions.

Four balls faced by Samson, four